



The Skill We Keep Teaching

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Teaching young people to spot a fake is, by almost any measure we have agreed to use, working. A 2024 meta-analysis of forty-nine experiments found that media-literacy training [Concession] improves people's discernment between true and false, lowers their belief in misinformation, and sharply cuts how willing they are to share it [Logos]. Twenty-five states have now written some form of media literacy into law. The case for more of it is easy to make, and I am inclined to make it.

2 And yet the studies that measure all this measure the wrong room. Almost none of them, only one in forty, look at what a person actually does online afterward; the rest record what people say they intend to do, or what they get right on a quiz. The gap matters more than it sounds, because the place we are trying to fix is not the quiz. It is the feed.

3 What we call a misinformation problem might be better described as an attention problem wearing the costume of a misinformation problem. The distinction is not a quibble. A platform does not lift a false story toward you because it is false; it lifts the story because the story keeps you there, and your staying is the thing being sold [Metaphor]. The economist Herbert Simon noticed the shape of this in 1971: a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention, and attention becomes the scarce good everyone competes for. Falsehood, it turns out, is unusually good at being interesting.

4 So the curriculum and the algorithm are not really opponents. They are working different problems. The lesson trains the reader; the system pays for the reader's gaze regardless of what the reader has learned, and the payment does not stop when the lesson ends. One report this year clocked false stories traveling roughly six times faster than true ones [Antithesis]. A classroom can make a student slower and more careful. It cannot make a lie less profitable to circulate.

5 There is something almost reassuring in that mismatch, and the reassurance is the part worth distrusting. A literacy mandate is visible, fundable, and easy to feel good about; it lets a legislature, a school board, a parent point to a thing that was done. Most of the new mandates arrived faster than the teacher training and the up-to-date materials did, so much of what is taught still describes a 2019 internet. The point is not that we are doing nothing. The point is that doing this lets the harder thing go unexamined.

6 I am not arguing against teaching it. The skill is real and the effect is real. I am only noticing that we have defined the problem as a deficit of skill in the reader, when the deficit that pays the bills sits one layer down, in an economy that would rather hold your attention with a lie than lose it to the truth [Shift / volta]. We taught the swimmer. We left the current alone.

Devices, and why they are here:

Concession (paragraph 1): “A 2024 meta-analysis of forty-nine experiments found that media-literacy training”

The writer grants the strongest version of the opposing view, that media literacy demonstrably works, citing the meta-analysis honestly before turning. The concession costs the writer ground and makes the later reframe land as discovery rather than a setup.

Logos (paragraph 1): “improves people's discernment between true and false, lowers their belief in misinformation, and sharply cuts how willing they are to share it”

The cluster of measured effects (discernment up, belief down, sharing down) builds the case on evidence, establishing that the writer respects the data even while preparing to question what it measures.

Metaphor (paragraph 3): “A platform does not lift a false story toward you because it is false; it lifts the story because the story keeps you there, and your staying is the thing being sold”

Casting the reader's attention as a good that is sold reframes the whole problem in one stroke; the implied market is the redefinition the piece turns on, so the figure carries the argument rather than decorating it.

Antithesis (paragraph 4): “One report this year clocked false stories traveling roughly six times faster than true ones”

Setting what a classroom can do (slow a student) against what it cannot do (make a lie unprofitable) crystallizes the gap between curriculum and incentive in balanced, opposed terms, the hinge the reframe depends on.

Shift / volta (paragraph 6): “I am only noticing that we have defined the problem as a deficit of skill in the reader, when the deficit that pays the bills sits one layer down, in an economy that would rather hold your attention with a lie than lose it to the truth”

The closing paragraph turns inward from argument to a precise restatement of the redefined problem, marking the move from what is conceded to what the writer actually claims: the deficit is in the economy, not the reader.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer claims a platform amplifies a false story not because it is false but because it keeps the reader engaged. This claim functions primarily to
 - A) recast the misinformation debate as a question of economic incentive rather than reader skill
 - B) warn readers to distrust any story that holds their attention for long
 - C) prove that false stories are inherently more interesting than true ones
 - D) concede that platforms cannot be held responsible for what their systems promote
2. The final two sentences of the closing paragraph, “We taught the swimmer. We left the current alone,” most directly contribute to the writer's tone by
 - A) mocking the educators and lawmakers who built the curricula
 - B) landing the argument in plain, unhurried language that withholds alarm even as it names the failure
 - C) expressing open despair that the problem can never be addressed
 - D) issuing an urgent call for readers to abandon media-literacy programs

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer A. The keyed answer captures the paragraph's pivot: the writer redefines the problem from a reader's deficit to a platform's incentive, which is the engine of the whole piece. The option about platforms escaping responsibility inverts the writer's stance, since the passage faults the system rather than excusing it. The option about false stories being inherently more interesting is too broad, treating an aside as the main claim. The option urging readers to distrust engaging stories imports a piece of practical advice the passage never offers, mistaking the reframe for a tip.

2. Answer B. The keyed answer fits the measured, reasoning tone: the clipped figure states the limit without raising its voice, consistent with a writer thinking aloud rather than rallying a crowd. The call-to-abandon option contradicts the writer, who states plainly he is not arguing against teaching it. The mockery option misreads the even tone as contempt, when the passage treats the educators' work as real. The despair option overstates the close, reading resignation into a sentence that diagnoses rather than gives up.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer concedes early that media literacy demonstrably works, then argues it addresses the wrong problem. How does granting the opposing case its real strength change the force of the reframe that follows?
2. The piece redefines a "misinformation problem" as an "attention problem." What is gained, and what might be lost or oversimplified, when an argument is won by redefining the terms rather than by adding new evidence?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The concession does real work because it removes the writer's easiest target. By agreeing that the training improves discernment and cuts sharing, the writer gives up the option of dismissing media literacy as useless, and forces a subtler claim: that an effective tool can still be aimed at the wrong layer of the problem. A reader who came in defending media literacy has nothing to push against on the facts, so the disagreement moves to where the writer wants it, the question of what the studies actually measure. The reframe lands harder precisely because the writer has already agreed the program works.
2. Redefining the problem lets the writer win at the level of framing: once attention rather than falsehood is the scarce resource being sold, the classroom and the algorithm stop looking like allies in the same fight. That is genuinely clarifying, and the Simon point and the six-times-faster figure give the redefinition some grounding. But redefinition can also smuggle in a false either-or. Calling it an attention problem instead of a misinformation problem implies the two are separable, when a more careful account might say literacy and incentive each carry part of the weight. The move is persuasive, but a skeptical reader should ask whether the costume metaphor hides a real overlap between the two problems.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that teaching individuals to detect misinformation leaves untouched the economic incentives that make false content profitable to spread. Write an essay that argues your own position on the following claim: that efforts to address misinformation should focus less on educating individual readers and more on changing the incentives that govern how platforms distribute content. In your response, develop a defensible position, support it with evidence and reasoning, and acknowledge a strong objection to your view.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the concession in the first paragraph as the writer's actual conclusion and miss that the piece turns against it. Point them to the marked concession and ask what the "And yet" at the start of the second paragraph signals about where the argument is headed.
- Students often treat the marked metaphor (attention as a good that is sold) as decoration rather than argument. Press them to see that the metaphor is the redefinition the whole piece depends on, so removing it would collapse the claim, which is the test for a load-bearing figure.
- Students may assume that because the writer questions media literacy, he opposes it. The passage explicitly states the opposite; he calls the skill and the effect real. The disagreement is about which problem the skill solves, not whether it works.
- Students may take the cited statistics (the meta-analysis effects, the six-times-faster figure) as the writer's main point rather than as evidence inside a larger reframe. Distinguish the data from the argument the data is recruited to serve.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches a genuine concession that the writer then turns against, giving students a clean model of concede-then-advance reasoning rather than both-sidesing. It shows how an argument can be won by redefinition (attention versus misinformation) instead of by piling on evidence, and it offers a single load-bearing metaphor and a clearly marked shift students can name and defend. The clipped closing figure set against the long cumulative sentences models how sentence length and structure carry tone in a measured, reasoning voice.